an era where disruption is the norm rather than the exception, it comes down to leading the team through difficult times. "A lot of empathy is needed in the corner office and boardrooms. Women are more confident and clearly the next era of AI will belong to them since they are very good at carrying a team," she thinks.

## MAKING THINGS COMFORTABLE

With the advent of technology, especially post Covid-19, work can easily be moved around regardless of location. Girotra says the concept of work from home (WFH) and flexi-hours are not just on paper.

Sonal Agrawal, Managing Partner, Accord India sees the more obvious presence of women across sectors as the consequence of a maturing talent pipeline, changing business models and a gradual shift in how India companies identify future leaders.

"Financial services and technology were among the earlier sectors to produce highly visible professional leaders since they offered relatively structured careers, measurable performance criteria, exposure to governance and risk apart from leadership opportunities across large organisations," she says.

The reasons for that change are quite complex, and in several ways, it reflects a changing India Inc. One cannot ignore the wealth of experience and how that's playing out. The women who entered the workforce in the 1990s and 2000s now have 20-30 years on the job. "That comes with exposure to operations, transformation, international markets, financial accountability and enterprise-wide decision-making," points out Agrawal.

She refers to structured programs by companies like Unilever, which has gone on to produce a slew of women CEOs in the consumer sector. As organisations evolve, the role of a CEO, too, has expanded. In line with a more dynamic external environment, that individual must understand and navigate disruption, pick up the nuances of changing consumer behaviour, manage multiple stakeholder relationships and get the organisation ready for the next phase of growth. Agrawal views this as a way to open CEO pathways from technology, consumer businesses, professional services and other functions. "This will sit alongside traditional finance, sales and manufacturing routes."

One can pin down a part of it to the growth in consumer-facing businesses to cover digital-first companies, healthcare or the way services has just taken off. "It has gone on to create leadership opportunities," she says.

That said, organisations have a larger responsibility. "It is critical for them to break the boys club when it comes to mindset on women," thinks Girotra. That includes getting married or taking time out for maternity leave. "All this makes it difficult for women to bring their best to the work spot," she emphasises. A potential fallout of all this is not having enough women at the mid-level. "They give up because of pressures at work and home, and that's a real loss."

That makes it incumbent on organisations to do a few things really well. "Flexible work arrangements, access to childcare support, and a more equitable sharing of caregiving responsibilities can influence how talented women remain in the workforce long enough to reach senior leadership," says Agrawal.

To her, succession planning is a process that must become more intentional.

By all counts, there is no dearth of talent. BT

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**MANISHA GIROTRA**
CEO, MOELIS INDIA



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**SONAL AGRAWAL**
MANAGING PARTNER, ACCORD INDIA